H2 Geography Paper 1 Suggested Answers

Cluster 1 Development, Economy and Environment

1 Resource 1 shows the global ranking of capital inflows, as measured by Foreign Direct Investment (FDI), between 2012 and 2022. Resource 2 shows the world's top cocoa producing countries. Resource 3 shows cocoa bean consumption per person in 2023. Resource 4 shows the share in the sales of an average chocolate bar. Resource 5 shows the top 10 chocolate companies worldwide by chocolate/confectionary sales.

(a) With reference to Resource 1, describe the changes in the global ranking of capital inflows between 2012 and 2022. [4]

- There was a visible shift in capital inflows toward East Asian economies, while the dominance of European countries in the top 10 rankings diminished over the decade.
- North America represented the region with the smallest change at the peak of the rankings.
- China (East Asia & Pacific) also exhibited high stability, consistently holding the Rank 2 position in both the starting year (2012) and the ending year (2022).
- Europe & Central Asia experienced the highest change (greatest decline) in representation.

Award 1 mark for each description of the changes in the global ranking of capital inflows, to a maximum of 4 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each description, where applicable.

(b) Using Resource 1, explain possible reasons for the changes in capital inflows into the East Asia & Pacific region between 2012 and 2022. [6]

- Many countries in the East Asia & Pacific region have maintained stable political environments and implemented pro-investment policies to attract foreign capital.
- The region has experienced rapid industrialisation and high economic growth rates, making it a primary destination for global capital seeking high returns.
- The region possesses a large and increasingly skilled labour force, providing the human capital necessary for complex production and high-value services.

Award 1 mark for each explanation for the changes in capital inflows into the East Asia & Pacific region, to a maximum of 6 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each explanation, where applicable.

(c) Explain how the concentration of capital inflows into certain countries might reinforce variations across space in levels of development. [4]

- The concentration of FDI into a specific country creates a cycle of cumulative causation.
- These improved conditions make the country even more attractive to future investors, creating a positive feedback loop, while other regions lag behind.

Award 1 mark for each explanation of how the concentration of capital inflows reinforces variations across space, to a maximum of 4 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each explanation, where applicable.

(d) With reference to Resources 2 and 3, compare the locations where inputs are sourced with those where products are consumed in the Global Production Network (GPN) of cocoa. [4]

- Both sourcing and consumption activities occur within certain countries in the tropical West African region
- Sourcing and consumption locations both show a strong presence in South America.
- Input sourcing is strictly concentrated in tropical latitudes In contrast, the highest per capita consumption of over 3kg is more geographically dispersed.

Award 1 mark for each comparison of locations, to a maximum of 4 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each comparison, where applicable.

(e) Using Resources 2, 4, and 5, explain how the GPN of cocoa creates an uneven economic impact across space. [6]

- Cocoa and chocolate companies capture a massive percentage of the retail value of an average chocolate bar. This profit is largely repatriated to the home countries rather than being reinvested in the tropical regions where the raw material is produced.
- Uneven economic impacts are further reinforced by the systemic marginalisation of primary producers in the Global South who receive a disproportionately small share of the final product value. This creates a significant developmental gap where producing nations provide the essential labour and land but see minimal economic returns.
- The spatial mismatch between sourcing locations and retail hubs ensures that secondary economic benefits, such as tax revenue and service-sector growth, remain concentrated in wealthy consumer markets. Because retail and intermediary services are typically situated in developed countries with high consumption rates, the positive economic impact of these activities do not reach the sourcing nations.

Award 1 mark for each explanation of how the GPN creates an uneven economic impact, to a maximum of 6 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each explanation, where applicable.

(f) Suggest ways in which the negative impacts of transnational corporations (TNCs) on host economies can be minimised. [6]

- Host governments can implement robust regulatory frameworks and environmental standards to curb the potentially exploitative practices of TNCs.
- Host economies can minimise negative impacts by mandating joint ventures or local sourcing requirements for TNCs operating within their borders.
- Governments can impose policies such as corporate taxation and limits on profit repatriation to ensure that wealth remains within the host country.

Award 1 mark for each suggestion of a way to minimise the negative impacts of TNCs, to a maximum of 6 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each suggestion, where applicable.

Cluster 2 Tropical Environments

2 Resource 6 shows the track and intensity of Tropical Cyclone Narelle. Resource 7A shows the sea surface temperature (SST) anomaly in the Eastern Pacific in November 2025. Resource 7B shows the SST anomaly in the Eastern Pacific in May 2026.

(a) Compare the rainfall characteristics of the humid tropics with those of the arid tropics. [4]

- Apart from the tropical rainforest (Af) zones, both the humid and arid tropics share a characteristic of distinct rainfall seasonality.
- The most significant difference lies in the total volume of annual rainfall, which is substantially higher in the humid tropics.
- The severity of the dry period differs, as the arid tropics experience a more permanent state of moisture deficit.

Award 1 mark for each comparison of rainfall characteristics, to a maximum of 4 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each comparison, where applicable.

(b) With reference to Resource 6, describe the track and changing intensity of Tropical Cyclone Narelle. [5]

- Tropical Cyclone Narelle originated as a disturbance in the Coral Sea (east of Australia) on March 17 and followed a generally westward/anti-clockwise trajectory.
- Narelle experienced a period of extreme and rapid intensification shortly after its formation in the Coral Sea. The system jumped from a Tropical Depression on March 17 to a Category 4 cyclone by March 18.
- The cyclone's intensity fluctuated significantly as it moved along the northern coast of Australia, experiencing a notable weakening phase.
- The system underwent a second intensification phase off the Western Australian coast before finally dissipating as it moved inland.

Award 1 mark for each description of the track and changing intensity of Tropical Cyclone Narelle, to a maximum of 5 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each description, where applicable.

(c) Cite data from Resource 6 to explain the surface and atmospheric conditions necessary for the formation of Tropical Cyclone Narelle. [6]

- Latitude provided the necessary Coriolis force to initiate rotation.
- The timing of the event in late summer (March) provided the critical thermal energy required to power the cyclone.

Award 1 mark for each explanation of the conditions necessary for cyclone formation, to a maximum of 6 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each explanation, where applicable.

(d) Explain how the rainfall generated by a tropical cyclone can impact geomorphic processes. [6]

- The intense rainfall from a tropical cyclone accelerates chemical weathering by providing the necessary moisture for the decomposition of rock minerals.

- Cyclone rainfall significantly reduces slope stability by increasing pore water pressure, which acts as a primary trigger for mass movement events.
- The high-intensity nature of tropical cyclone rainfall promotes mechanical water erosion through powerful raindrop impact and concentrated surface runoff.

Award 1 mark for each explanation of how rainfall impacts geomorphic processes, to a maximum of 6 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each explanation, where applicable.

(e) With reference to Resources 7A and 7B, contrast the SST anomalies in the eastern equatorial Pacific Ocean between November 2025 and May 2026. [3]

- The primary contrast lies in the sign and magnitude of the SST anomalies, which shift from a cool to an extreme warm phase.
- The spatial extent of the anomalies differs significantly.
- The location of the peak anomalies shifted eastward, becoming more concentrated along the South American coast by 2026.

Award 1 mark for each contrast of SST anomalies, to a maximum of 3 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each contrast, where applicable.

(f) Account for the SST anomalies shown in the eastern equatorial Pacific Ocean as shown in Resources 7A and 7B. [6]

- The negative SST anomalies are accounted for by an intensification of this normal Walker Circulation, known as the La Niña phase.
- The extreme positive SST anomalies result from a major breakdown and reversal of the Walker Circulation, characteristic of an El Niño event.

Award 1 mark for each explanation of the SST anomalies, to a maximum of 6 marks. Award a maximum of 1 additional mark for further development of each explanation, where applicable.

Section B
Cluster 1 Development, Economy and Environment

3 Evaluate the success of strategies to manage conflicts over transboundary water resources. [20]

Possible Approaches:

Candidates could approach the question by making a judgement on whether some strategies are more successful than others through a consideration of the relative strengths and limitations of the strategies. The strategies could be compared in relation to criteria such as costs, ability to reduce tensions, equitable distribution of water and effectiveness over time. These strategies could include international treaties, river-basin organisations, joint infrastructure projects, and third-party mediation. They could also include strategies implemented at different scales or involving different stakeholders.

Candidates could also approach the question by making a judgement on whether the same strategies have been more successful in some transboundary river basins than others through a consideration of two or more case studies. Candidates could evaluate whether the strategies in each case achieved the intended aims. Candidates could also analyse unintended negative impacts, such as unequal benefits or the continued dominance of more powerful riparian states. Candidates could analyse contextual factors such as differences in political power, dependence on the shared water resource, political will, enforcement mechanisms and resources available, which may have contributed to variations in success between these places.

Levels marked using **Generic Level Descriptors for H2 essays**

4 'Multilateral institutions have more influence on economic activities than states.'

Evaluate this statement. [20]

Possible Approaches:

Candidates could approach the question by making a judgement on whether multilateral institutions have greater influence on economic activities than states through a consideration of criteria such as the spatial scale of their influence, ability to establish and enforce rules, financial resources and impact on firms. Candidates could consider economic activities such as international trade, foreign investment, production and development finance. Candidates could compare the influence of multilateral institutions with state actions such as taxation, regulation, subsidies, infrastructure provision and restrictions on foreign investment.

Candidates could also approach the question by making a judgement on whether multilateral institutions have greater influence than states in some contexts rather than others through a consideration of two or more case studies. Candidates could analyse contextual factors such as the economic power of states, dependence on international loans and trade, the institutional capacity of governments and the mobility of firms. Candidates could also consider how powerful states influence the decisions of multilateral institutions, which may affect the relative significance of each actor in shaping economic activities.

Levels marked using **Generic Level Descriptors for H2 essays**

Cluster 2 Tropical Environments

5 'The impacts of fluvial floods in the humid tropics are not all negative.'

Evaluate this statement. [20]

Possible Approaches:

Candidates could approach the question by making a judgement on whether the positive impacts of fluvial floods are significant when compared with their negative impacts through a consideration of criteria such as the spatial scale of the impacts, the temporal scale of the impacts and the stakeholders affected. Candidates could consider positive impacts such as the deposition of fertile alluvium, replenishment of soil moisture, groundwater recharge and support for floodplain ecosystems and fisheries. Negative impacts could include deaths, displacement, damage to infrastructure, disruption of economic activities and the spread of water-borne diseases.

Candidates could also approach the question by making a judgement on whether the balance of positive and negative impacts differs between places through a consideration of two or more case studies. Candidates could analyse the contextual factors such as flood magnitude and duration, population density, land use, level of preparedness and the ability of communities to recover, which may have contributed to variations in the impacts. Candidates could also consider whether some groups, such as floodplain farmers, experience greater benefits, while low-income urban residents experience more severe negative impacts.

Levels marked using **Generic Level Descriptors for H2 essays**

6 Evaluate the factors influencing the formation of karst landforms in the humid tropics. [20]

Possible Approaches:

Candidates could approach the question by making a judgement on whether some factors have a greater influence on the formation of karst landforms than others through a consideration of criteria such as the rate of limestone dissolution, the scale of the resulting landforms and the range of surface and underground features produced. Candidates could consider factors such as limestone lithology, rock structure, temperature, precipitation, vegetation, hydrology, relief and time. Candidates could also consider how these factors interact rather than operate independently.

Candidates could also approach the question by making a judgement on whether the same factors are more influential in some humid tropical karst landscapes than others through a consideration of two or more case studies. Candidates could analyse contextual factors such as limestone purity and thickness, the density of joints and bedding planes, rainfall intensity, soil carbon dioxide levels, tectonic uplift and changes in base level, which may have contributed to variations in karst formation between these places. Candidates could also evaluate whether suitable geology is the fundamental requirement, while climatic and hydrological conditions determine the rate and extent of landform development.

Levels marked using **Generic Level Descriptors for H2 essays**

Levels	Marks	Generic Level Descriptors for H2 Essays
5	18–20	Evaluation is consistently analytical and coherent. Response is well-supported by relevant material, including the effective use of examples. Response features accurate geographical knowledge and reflects good understanding of the subject content relevant to the question.
4	14–17	Evaluation is analytical and coherent. Response is mostly well-supported by relevant material, including the appropriate use of examples. Response features accurate geographical knowledge and reflects adequate understanding of the subject content relevant to the question.
3	10–13	Evaluation is broadly analytical and generally coherent. Response is moderately well-supported by relevant material, including some appropriate use of examples. Response features accurate geographical knowledge and reflects adequate understanding of the subject content relevant to the question.
2	6–9	Response is largely descriptive with limited analysis and evaluation. Response is partly coherent and may lack clarity in parts. Response is poorly supported by relevant materials, including the limited use of examples. Response features inaccurate geographical knowledge and poor understanding of the subject content relevant to the question.
1	1–5	Response is descriptive with no analysis or evaluation. Response is fragmented and lacks clarity. Response consists of unsupported assertions. Response features largely inaccurate geographical knowledge and a lack of understanding of the subject content relevant to the question.
0	0	No creditworthy response

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